

A Panegyric to Henri II ["Venite à l'ombra de' gran Gigli d'oro..."]

Annibal Caro (tr. Haider Ali)

1.

Come to the shade of stately fleurs-de-lis,
Sweet muses, faithfuls of my hyacinths,
And intertwining both as one,
Let's weave some garlands for our gods;
And you, my Lord, that as my sun I love,
Lest they be ruined by the lesser sun,
Do bless them with your storied name,
So they may merit endless praise.
To place a crown upon the heads of kings,
I do not dare, though others urge in vain,
For courage flees me, as does aid;
Yet, you alone unseal me, and dispense
Parnassus; and you rouse me, you direct
My style, my language, and my sense,
So I may discourse loftily, and write.

2.

She sits, as if a sink between two seas,
And two great mountains, *Alps* and *Pyrenees*:
Europa's most serene expanse,
And all that's circled by the sun,
Replete with treasures, tribes, and holy mounds
That to our God she raises, and maintains.
She's rich with precious veins of ore,
A mother of the arts, arms, love:
New *Cybele*, to whom, most joyously,
The elder cedes her chariot and lions:
It seems that you alone do crown
With all her towers *Italy*, and yourself,
And thus you say, "Go, my *Gauls*! Now, my *Gauls*!
The *Indians*, *Persians*, and the *Turks*—
Conquer them all, and form a single realm."

3.

And of this mother, generous and bright,
Mother as well of Heaven's paladins,
There reign today, amongst us now,
Some other *Joves*, with other sons.
They're worthier of the incense and the shrines
Than ever, ancient *Saturn*, yours had been,
For each discerns his honour's root
In meekness and in fear of God.
Gaze at the conqueror, unmatched *Henri*,
Of once-unconquered *Caesar*. Hail, all hail!
For he, the dearest friend of *Christ*,
With piety, with honesty, with arms,
Lifting the poor, and punishing the cruel—

Disdaining marble, spiting bronze—
Does consecrate the statues of his land.

4.

Behold how gentle, yet severe, he is;
Unto himself, he is the law and crown:
See *Iris*, with *Bellona* too,
Behind him, *Themis* just ahead;
See *Reason*, *Wisdom*, *Truth* surrounding him,
Such dignified and constant company.
Hear how his thunder roars above
The *Lycaons*, and the wicked *Giants*,
And count the thousand corpses he's subdued,
And those he strikes at, those he menaces,
From *Ossan* and *Olympian* peaks,
Hurling the rent-up mountains to the skies;
When rebel *Typhon* shall, by him, be slain,
His thunderbolts at last retired,
The world shall celebrate a glorious peace!

5.

His *Juno*, sat at such a humble height,
Rejoices, happy and secure in love,
As no disdain, nor slightest care,
For *Io* penetrates her heart.
Her merit, and your valour, noble dame,
Of name and soul's inviolate and pure.
By *Fortune*'s serendipity,
And providence of God supreme,
You found the greatest kingdom, and its king;
And from his splendour and your seed
May rise anew the long-lost hope
Of *Flora*, and of *Italy* far and wide,
For ever if your rays to her extend,
Enslaved and ruined though she be,
Then *Health* and *Freedom* will, to her, attend.

6.

The true *Minerva*, and so truly born
From *Jove* himself—from all his wisdom she,
Daughter and sister now of kings,
And soon their mother and their spouse.
Virgin, who with magnificence is crowned,
A favoured star who's hidden from the sun,
You've kept yourself from earthly loves,
To cast your light on doleful *Night*;
A living pearl, most precious and most bright,
What thing has *Phoebus*, worthier than you?
He lives for you, and reigns through you,
His burnished lamp with yours does further glow:
So every heart now flares, and mine inflames,

And so I strive to fly and sing
Amongst your swans, though I be maimed and hoarse.

7.

There's *Cynthia* too, and there *Endymion* was:
A pair that would so happy be today
 Had not that flower, for her grown,
 Been cut when barely blossoming.
But what, if *Love* imposes sleep as law,
If he has dulled what thus could longer live,
 If death was not regret to him,
 But life eternal, by her side?
How many hearts and faces, sweet and glad,
Are graced by you, *Cytherean*, and your band,
 How many fierce and noble ones,
Who by their deeds ensure their skyward way?
If they're not gods, who else could they then be—
 What other race is suited more
To club, to thyrsus, and to trident too?

8.

My song, if virtue joined with shining acts
Celestial be, for heaven they are fit,
 These royal souls of whom I speak;
Offer them humble flowers in their name,
Extend them in my stead, and say, "though not
 Of gold-string, nor with gems inlaid,
They're of yourselves, and shall be of the stars."